

CHAPTER 1

WHO YA GONNA CALL?

We are learning the secrets of France's richest family. At least, they appear to be the richest family in France. They have businesses with annual revenues of about \$70 billion—and more than a quarter of a million employees. But we'll bet you've never heard of them. And you've almost certainly never seen a picture of them. They are the Mulliez family from the north of France. Discreet. Private. Unostentatious.

They own huge discount shopping centers all over France and much of Europe. They were able to figure out how to run large-surface, low-price, rapid-turnover merchandising enterprises. Once they had the system figured out, they were able to apply it to several different retail industries.

The Mulliez family has been in business for half a century. They have managed to create one of the world's biggest and most profitable family business empires. And they have done it while also creating one of the biggest and most successful families.

From a business perspective, they followed the same three-step success formula John D. Rockefeller famously prescribed: They got to work early. They stayed late. They “struck oil” in the discount retail business.

But the really remarkable thing is the way the Mulliezes have been able to work together as a family, providing all the members—including over 520 in the extended family, not just those who happen to run the businesses—with substantial and enduring wealth.

What's their secret? We don't know. But we can guess.

First, it helps to have a big family. The disadvantage of a large family is that you have to split up the wealth among more people. But the advantage is that you have more hands to do the work. And the odds are you will have some clever people in the group.